consisting of Pakistan, Afghanistan and Iran, and the role of the special representative appointed by the UN secretary general. But a month later, events took an unexpected turn. On 2 March 1981, a Pakistan International Airlines Boeing on its way to Kabul and subsequently Damascus was hijacked, causing a great deal of political drama in Pakistan. The hijacked plane had a hundred and forty-eight people on board. On 6 March 1981, in Kabul, the hijackers killed one of the hostages, a Pakistani diplomat who had been an aide de camp to Zulfikar Ali Bhutto. The hijackers identified themselves with an organisation called Al-Zul-fikar and claimed that Zulfikar's son Murtaza

Bhutto was its secretary general. The original demand of the hijackers was for the release of ninety-two people from prison in Pakistan. The Pakistani government offered the release of only fifteen of these prisoners. The hijackers refused the offer and on 9 March, took the plane to Damascus. There they demanded the release of fifty-five persons by 12 March. Zia finally conceded to the demands of the hijackers and announced the release of the prisoners before the deadline. In his broadcast, he referred to the prisoners as rotten eggs. While Pakistan publicly criticised the Afghans, accusing them of collusion with the hijackers, they praised Syria for the sake of the record.

Now Zia had a four-point programme for the resolution of the Afghanistan crisis: the withdrawal of Soviet troops; the maintenance of Afghanistan as an Islamic country; the repatriation of about two million Afghan refugees in Pakistan; and the provision of an opportunity to the Afghan people to have a system of government of their choice.